

TRAPPED IN AMBER

BIRD HATCHLING

Small animals can get caught in the golden-yellow, sticky resin that oozes out of the bark of certain trees. As the resin fossilizes into amber, it creates a seal, preserving delicate soft tissue such as the skin and muscles of creatures trapped inside in exquisite detail. This means that amber fossils offer some of the clearest insights into the prehistoric world. One such glimpse comes from this fossil, which contains the hatchling of an extinct bird known as an enantiornithine. Trapped in the fossil's resin prison, parts of the bird's skull, feet, and wings can be seen in extraordinary detail. Hundreds of different species of ancient creatures, including birds and insects and even portions of dinosaur tails, have been found preserved in amber.

Tiny, clawed wings
can just about
be seen with
the naked eye.



EARLY BIRDS

The enantiornithines were a group of birds capable of powered flight. Their fossils show that they had toothed beaks and wing claws. These tiny birds became extinct at the end of the Cretaceous Period along with the pterosaurs, marine reptiles, and most dinosaurs.

AT A GLANCE

- **YEAR OF DISCOVERY** 2017
- **PLACE** Myanmar
- **STUDIED BY** Lida Xing and colleagues
- **LIVED** 99 MYA



Preserved
impression of
feather

